

ALESSANDRO PIZZIGOLOTTO

🏛️ **Department of Economics, University of Copenhagen**

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Postdoctoral Researcher

September 2023 – present

Department of Economics

UNIVERSITY OF COPENHAGEN

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics

2018 – 2023

NORWEGIAN SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS (NHH)

Doctoral Thesis *Essays on Empirical Political Economy and Household Behaviour*

Examiners Vincent Somville (NHH, chair), Gloria Gennaro (UCL), Matia Vannoni (KCL)

Supervisors *Katrine V. Løken, Jósef Sigurdsson*

Research Visits Stockholm University: October 2021 – July 2022

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM): January 2022

MSc. in Economics and Finance

2014 – 2017

UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI PADOVA, *with distinction*

Exchange Student University of Helsinki, MSocSc. in Economics

Curriculum Banking and Finance

BSc. in Economics and Management

2011 – 2014

UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI PADOVA

High School Diploma in Software Engineering

2011

ISTITUTO TECNICO INDUSTRIALE STATALE “F. SEVERI”, 100/100

TEACHING AND RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary: Political Economy, Applied Microeconomics

Secondary: Cultural Economics, Economic History, Household Finance, Labour Economics

REFERENCES

Jeanet Sinding Bentzen, Professor

UNIVERSITY OF COPENHAGEN

Department of Economics

Øster Farimagsgade 5, building 26, office 26.2.26

jeanet.bentzen@econ.ku.dk (Advisor and PI)

Katrine V. Løken, Professor

NORWEGIAN SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS (NHH)

Department of Economics

Helleveien 30, 5045 Bergen, Norway

katrine.loken@nhh.no (Supervisor)

Jósef Sigurdsson, Associate Professor

STOCKHOLM UNIVERSITY

Department of Economics

Universitetsvägen 10A, 114 18 Stockholm, Sweden

josef.sigurdsson@su.se (Supervisor)

Jaakko Meriläinen, Associate Professor

STOCKHOLM SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS

Department of Economics

Sveavägen 65, 11383 Stockholm, Sweden

jaakko.merilainen@hhs.se (Co-Author)

PUBLICATIONS

Divine Policy

with [Jeanet Sinding Bentzen](#) and Lena Lindbjerg Sperling

The Impact of Religion in Government

American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, Volume 18 (1), January 2026, p. 195–247.

Press Coverage: [AEA Research Highlights Article](#), [VoxEU](#), [EurekAlert!](#), [Berlingske](#).

Can policies shape personal values and beliefs? To examine, we exploit the staggered introduction of faith-based initiatives across US states. Our difference-in-differences analysis reveals that the initiatives strengthened religiosity and conservative-religious social views, such as attitudes against homosexuals. The evidence points to causal effects; we find no systematic differences prior to implementation, the results are robust to restricting comparison to contiguous counties and to conducting triple-differences estimation exploiting treatment heterogeneity. A key explanation, in line with standard models of religion and supported by data on nonprofit organizations, is that the initiatives facilitated the establishment of faith-based organizations.

Essays on Empirical Political Economy and Household Behaviour

PhD Dissertation, Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), August 2023.

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

Credit Shocks and Populism

with [Nicolò Fraccaroli](#)

This paper shows that credit shocks are key drivers of populist sentiment. Exploiting spatial variation in exposure to an exogenous lending cut by a large German bank in 2007–08, we find that exposure to the credit shock leads to a persistent increase in populist political preferences. To explore the shift in demand for populism activated by the shock, we measure the degree of populist rhetoric and the salience of bank-related topics to each party over time using a machine learning technique on the corpus of parliamentary speeches in Germany. A county-level analysis suggests that the underlying mechanism lies in the perceived decay of the local economy across voters that stems from the credit shock. A machine learning decomposition of the individual causal effects indicates that labour market history is the most important factor shaping the response in populist preferences.

Volcanic Protests

with [Jaakko Meriläinen](#), [Matti Mitrinen](#), [Arash Nekoei](#) and [Jósef Sigurdsson](#)

This paper provides the first empirical evidence supporting the “folk hypothesis” that the 1783 volcanic eruption in Iceland contributed to unrest during the French Revolution. Using estimates of sulfur dioxide concentrations and historical protest data, we show that regions more exposed to the eruption experienced significantly more subsistence riots both before and during the Revolution. A one standard deviation increase in haze exposure led to a 9-12 percentage point increase in riot probability in the years immediately following the eruption, an effect that carries through during the revolutionary years. We propose a mechanism linking the eruption to social unrest through its negative impact on agriculture and subsequent increases in grain prices. Our findings contribute to the broader literature on the causes of the French Revolution and the relationship between climatic conditions and social conflict.

Learning from a Systemic Banking Crisis’ Experience

The Long-Run Impact on Borrowing Behaviour

with [Michele Cantarella](#) and [Nicolò Fraccaroli](#)

Does the experience of a banking crisis has an effect on households’ portfolios? We investigate this question by focusing on households that migrated to Germany between 1950 and the 2007 financial crisis. Combining data on migrants from 123 different countries with data on systemic banking crises, we identify the impact of the crisis’ experience through the variation in the timing of arrival. We compare households’ portfolios of those with a household head that experienced a systemic banking crisis in her country of ancestry with those that did not. Focusing on loan portfolios, we find that household that witnessed at least a crisis earlier in their life are less likely to hold consumer loans than those that never experienced a crisis. Moreover,

we show that the probability of borrowing is lower for migrants who experienced multiple crises compared to those that experienced a single episode, suggesting a cumulative effect of banking shocks. We propose analogous evidence on real estate portfolios. Overall, our results suggest that the cost financial crises is not limited to the short-term effects driven by losses in wealth and income, but rather a long-lasting effect due to households changing their behaviour.

Written in the Taxes

with Jeanet Sinding Bentzen

Insights on the Role of Religion from Millions of Tax Statements

Religion is not just a private matter. Using full-count administrative data from IRS filings for nonprofit organizations covering tax years 2009 to 2023, we document its pervasive role in public life. Through text analysis of their missions and names, we find three patterns. First, while explicitly religious domains—such as churches and faith-based congregations—are almost entirely religious, we also uncover a substantial religious footprint in areas typically perceived as secular, including international aid and pregnancy-related services. Religious pregnancy organizations, for instance, emphasize crisis support with faith-based language, whereas secular counterparts focus on reproductive healthcare and access. Second, religious philanthropy is directed primarily toward human beneficiaries: animal welfare and environmental topics are almost entirely secular, while the topics in which religious organizations are most concentrated serve people—suggesting that religion shapes the direction of prosocial activity rather than simply its level. Third, mission statements reveal substantive value differences between religious and secular organizations, and organization names can also carry explicit religious markers in some cases, so surface identifiers capture only part of the underlying differences. Together, our findings provide a new, large-scale perspective on how religion shapes the goals, language, and scope of nonprofit activity in the United States.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

AØKA08087U Advanced Development Economics - Macro Aspects <i>University of Copenhagen</i>	Guest Lecturer, Fall 2025 <i>MSc/PhD Level</i>
STR421 Competitive Strategy <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)</i>	Teaching Assistant, Spring 2023 <i>Master's Level</i>
ECN400 Macroeconomic Theory and Policy <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)</i>	Teaching Assistant, Fall 2020 <i>Master's Level</i>
ECN401 Applied Microeconomic Theory <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)</i>	Teaching Assistant, Spring 2020 <i>Master's Level</i>
ECN402 Econometrics <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)</i>	Teaching Assistant, Fall 2019 – Fall 2022 <i>Master's Level</i>
ECO433 Empirical Strategies for Causal Analysis <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)</i>	Teaching Assistant, Spring 2019 <i>Master's Level</i>

PRESENTATIONS AND CONFERENCES

2026	Helsinki GSE. SODAS Data Discussion (<i>joint with co-author</i> , University of Copenhagen). ASREC Europe 2026 Conference (University of Warwick Venice, Italy, <i>planned</i>).
2025	SPARRC Methodology Workshop 2025 (UCSD, CA). ASREC Europe 2025 Conference (University of Copenhagen).
2024	ASREC 2024 Conference (Chapman University (Orange County, CA), attending the annual workshop). 2 nd Workshop in Economic History (Uppsala University, Sweden).

- 2023** Graduate Students in International Political Economy (GSIPE) Workshop (online). 5th Annual COMPTXT Conference 2023 (University of Strathclyde, Glasgow). APSA Annual Meeting 2023 (Los Angeles, canceled).
- 2022** Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM, Political Economy Group, Mexico City). University of Gothenburg. FAIR Midway Conference 2022 (Sommarøy, Norway, Poster Session). Norwegian School of Economics (Brownbag, CELE Coffee Meeting, Emerging Research Seminar)
- 2021** Scandinavian PhD Seminar (online). EPSA Virtual Conference 2021 (*joint with co-author*). XXXII Villa Mondragone International Economic Seminar (*joint with co-author*, Rome Tor Vergata/online). 2nd Monash-Warwick-Zurich Text-as-Data Conference (online). IFABS 2021 Oxford Conference (Saïd Business School, Oxford/online). Stockholm University (SU Labor Fika, Microwave Seminar). Joint Bank of England, the European Central Bank, King's College London and King's Business School Conference on new methods and applications for macroeconomic policy (*joint with co-author*, London/online).
- 2020** Norwegian School of Economics (Friday Lunch Seminar, Emerging Research Seminar). INET/Young Scholars Initiative: New Economic Questions (Political Economy of Europe Working Group (*joint with co-author*), Financial Stability Working Group, online).

RELEVANT SKILLS

Programming	C/C++, Java, PHP (pre-graduate), Python (intermediate), R (advanced), MATLAB (basic), Typescript (basic)
Software	STATA (advanced), Excel, mysql (intermediate), QGIS (intermediate), L ^A T _E X
Language	Italian (Native), English (Fluent), Norwegian (Basic) and Danish (Survival Skills)

AWARDS, FELLOWSHIPS AND GRANTS

SPARRC Seed Research Grant (150,000 USD) <i>Templeton Foundation</i>	2025–2027
Funding the Role of Religion in Crisis Response (ROREC) Seed Project (PI: Jeanet Sinding Bentzen), focused on using natural experiments and NLP techniques on U.S. non-profits to study the impact of religion and prosociality on disaster relief efforts. More than a half of the grant is allocated to my 2026-2027 stipend.	
University Lecturer (50%) <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), Department of Economics</i>	October 2022 – August 2023
Erasmus+ Scholarship for Training (at Barcelona GSE) <i>European Commission</i>	Summer 2019
Ph.D. Research Scholar (Full-Stipend) <i>Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), Department of Economics</i>	2018–2022
Erasmus+ Scholarship <i>European Commission</i>	2015–2016

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

Refereeing Activities. *Swiss Journal of Economics and Statistics*, *Journal of Economic Growth*.
Other. Meta-reviewer for the 2026 *European Association of Young Economists* (EAYE) Annual Meeting.

PAST APPOINTMENTS AND PROFESSIONAL EMPLOYMENT

Graduate Research Assistant

July 2017 – July 2018

European Central Bank

Sonnemannstraße 20, 60314 Frankfurt am Main, Germany

Research Assistant related to the Household Finance and Consumption Network (HFCN) at the Directorate General Research of the European Central Bank. Main Research Project: “**Monetary Policy and Household Inequality**”. *Principal Investigators: Oreste Tristani, Jiří Sláček.*

Credit Analyst Assistant

June 2014 – August 2014

Cassa Centrale Banca S.p.A.

Via Segantini, 5, 38122 Trento, Italy

Web Developer, Software Developer and Webmaster

November 2011 – March 2013

Bortolami Ricambi s.a.s.

Via Marco Polo, 35020 Albignasego, Italy